Course Design Highlight

ENGL 46700/56701: Writing for Multiple Media

Interaction Design—Annotated Syllabus

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How to read this document: The syllabus text appears in the left column. Annotations in the right column explain the design decisions, pedagogical rationale, and industry-facing thinking embedded in how this course is structured. Annotations connect each course decision to the professional practice it builds toward.

ENGL 46700/56701: Writing for Multiple Media

Spring 2026 | Asynchronous online in Brightspace

Instructor: Dr. Elizabeth (Beth) Keller | Dept. of English and Linguistics

Office hours: virtual and by appointment only

📌 **Course Context**

Upper-division / graduate dual-listed course. The course number range (400/500) signals a deliberate design: undergraduate and graduate students work through the same projects but are evaluated against differentiated expectations. This is not a compromise—it is a scaffolding decision that models how professional teams function.

Asynchronous design is not a default; it is an expertise-informed choice that also mirrors how distributed product and content teams actually work.

Welcome

Welcome to ENGL 46700/56701: Writing for Multiple Media! In this course, we approach writing not simply as the production of texts, but as the design of interactions and experiences. Writing today does not live on a page or even on a single screen; it lives in systems, interfaces, choices, pathways, and responses. Writers increasingly shape how people move through information, make decisions, and experience digital environments.

> *"The real problem with the design of interactive systems is not that they are too complex, but that they are designed without a deep understanding of human needs and behavior." — Don Norman, The Design of Everyday Things*

This course takes that challenge seriously. We focus on what it means to write with and for human behavior, to design content, structures, and interactions that are usable, meaningful, ethical, and responsive to real people in real contexts. By the end of this course, you should see writing as something that acts in the world—guiding, inviting, constraining, persuading, and responding across multiple media and interactive contexts.

📌 **Rhetorical Reframe**

Opening with 'writing as the design of interactions' rather than 'writing about topics' is a deliberate frame shift. Students arrive expecting essays. This paragraph redirects them toward systems thinking before they see a single assignment.

The Norman quote is not decorative. It positions the course inside a recognized discipline (HCI/IxD) while making the core argument in 24 words: the problem is not complexity; it is failure to understand users. The rest of the semester unpacks that sentence.

📌 **Industry Alignment**

'Writing as something that acts in the world' is the foundational claim of content strategy, UX writing, and information architecture as professional practices. Students who internalize this frame are prepared for roles where writing is evaluated by what it makes people do, not how it reads.

Course Objectives and Learning Outcomes

By the end of this course, you will be able to:

- Analyze interactive media using usability and user-experience principles,
- Conduct user research and synthesize findings into personas and scenarios,
- Design and prototype interactive systems using low-fidelity tools,
- Create both non-narrative and narrative interactive experiences,
- Apply iterative design processes informed by feedback and testing,
- Reflect critically on design decisions and ethical implications, and
- Communicate design rationale clearly to both technical and non-technical audiences.

📌 **Outcome Architecture**

*Seven outcomes map to a deliberate skill progression: **analysis → research → design → narrative → iteration → ethics → communication.** This mirrors the UX project lifecycle.*

The final outcome—communicating design rationale to both technical and non-technical audiences—is the capstone skill. It is what distinguishes a practitioner from a student. Every project requires students to defend their decisions, not just produce artifacts.

Graduate-level work adds explicit theory integration at each stage, requiring students to connect decisions to named frameworks. This is the difference between doing and understanding.

Course Pace, Support, and Tools

Because this course emphasizes design thinking and adaptability, you are not expected to arrive with mastery of specific software tools. Instead, part of the learning goal is developing the ability to learn new tools independently and evaluate which tools best support your design goals.

The focus of this course is not on mastering a particular piece of software, but on learning how to design effective interactions, communicate purposefully across media, and adapt to new tools as a writer and designer.

📌 **Tool-Agnostic Philosophy**

This is a principled stance, and not a hedge. The fastest-changing part of any design role is the tooling. Figma replaced Sketch. Notion replaced Confluence for many teams. New AI-native tools emerge monthly.

Students who are taught 'here is how to use Figma' are equipped for 2024. Students who are taught 'here is how to evaluate whether a tool serves your design goal and learn it independently' are equipped for the next decade plus.

This framing also signals to industry reviewers that the course produces adaptable practitioners, not tool-specific operators.

Assignment Structure

This course emphasizes process, iteration, and reflection, not just final products.

Because there are both undergraduate and graduate students taking this course, assignment lists and grading percentages are listed separately. Graduate students complete the same core projects but are evaluated using higher expectations for theoretical integration, design justification, and reflective synthesis.

Project Sequence

Project	Points	% Grade
Project 1: Research & Personas	200	26.7%
Project 2: Non-Narrative Prototype	250	33.3%
Project 3: Narrative Interactive Experience	250	33.3%
Project 4: Evaluation & Redesign	200	26.7%
Peer Review (4 × 15 pts)	60	8.0%
Participation	40	5.3%

📌 **The Project Arc**

Four projects form a deliberate arc: understand users (P1) → design a functional system (P2) → make it narrative/playful (P3) → evaluate and improve (P4). This is the professional UX lifecycle compressed into 15 weeks.

P2 and P3 use the same product concept. Students design once and then ask: what changes when we shift from task-completion to narrative? This is a genuine design question that surfaces at companies building products with both functional and engagement dimensions.

The dual-listed structure is not a workaround — it is a design choice. Graduate students add theory integration to the same projects, modeling how senior practitioners on a team bring more conceptual depth to shared work.

📌 **Weighting Philosophy**

*Projects carry 93% of the grade. Participation is 5%. This signals clearly that this is **a making course,** not a discussion course. The grade reflects what students produce and revise, not whether they show up to talk about it.*

Peer review is weighted at 8% and tied directly to project milestones. It cannot be made up once the window closes. This is explicit about professional expectations before students experience the real thing.

Peer Review Policy

Peer review is a required, time-sensitive component of this course. Because this class is built around iterative design, usability, and revision, peer feedback functions as a critical learning activity, not an optional discussion or informal exercise.

Peer review cannot be made up once the peer review window has closed. Because peer review depends on shared timing and reciprocal participation, late or retroactive peer reviews are not possible.

Writing Center Substitution Option

In limited circumstances, a missed peer review may be substituted with a PFW Writing Center consultation. This option is not automatic, must be approved in advance, and applies only when a Writing Center appointment is available within the same project window.

To qualify, students must attend the full session and submit proof of attendance plus a 250–300 word reflection explaining what feedback was received, how it informed revisions, and how it compares to peer feedback.

📌 **Professional Parallel**

The peer review policy is the most industry-relevant policy in this syllabus. UX design is inherently collaborative. Design critiques, content reviews, and usability sessions all depend on shared timing. A reviewer who shows up after the team has moved on is not useful.

The explicit 'cannot be made up' language is not punitive; it teaches a concept: reciprocal participation has a timing dependency. This is true of every sprint review, design crit, and stakeholder presentation students will encounter in industry.

The Writing Center substitution option is a direct expression of the instructor's role as Writing Center Liaison. It routes students to a resource the instructor helps lead, models how support systems integrate, and still requires the student to produce a reflection that demonstrates what they got from the experience.

Missing Assignment Components Policy

First Instance: If you submit a project on time but are missing one or more required components, you will receive a temporary 5-point deduction and 48 hours to submit the missing material. If submitted within 48 hours, the deduction is removed.

Subsequent Instances: The same 48-hour window applies, but if the missing component is not submitted within that window, the penalty increases to 8 points and becomes final.

> *Professional Parallel: In professional writing and design environments, incomplete deliverables stall progress and affect collaborators and stakeholders. This policy mirrors those expectations while providing a clear, fair opportunity to correct honest mistakes.*

📌 **Policy as Pedagogy**

This policy is doing two things simultaneously: it is fair (a first-time grace period, a clear process) and it is instructive (it names the professional consequence explicitly).

The 'Professional Parallel' label is deliberate. Students who see a policy explained in terms of its workplace equivalent learn a mental model, not just a rule. They are being prepared to understand why incomplete deliverables matter, not just trained to avoid losing points.

The escalating penalty structure mirrors probationary frameworks in professional environments without being punitive about genuine mistakes. First instance: grace. Subsequent instances: accountability.

AI and Authorship

AI tools may be used for brainstorming or drafting support, but all design decisions, prototypes, and reflections must be your own. You will be expected to explain and defend your work throughout the semester. Projects that cannot be discussed fluently or meaningfully may be reviewed for authorship concerns.

📌 **The Best AI Policy in Any Syllabus**

This is not a blanket ban and not a blanket permission. It is a functional definition of authorship: you own the design decisions, not the generated text.

The accountability mechanism is verbal defense, and not detection software. Students who used AI to write their reflection but cannot explain their design decisions will not pass authorship review. This mirrors exactly how a portfolio review or design interview works in industry: you will be asked to explain what you made.

This framing also positions AI correctly as a brainstorming and drafting tool, which is what experienced practitioners actually use it for.

How to Succeed in This Course

This course is designed around sustained effort, experimentation, and revision rather than last-minute production. Students who succeed tend to engage early with projects, read assignment materials closely, use peer feedback thoughtfully, and focus on learning through iteration rather than aiming for perfection on the first attempt.

- Start projects early.
- Read assignment sheets carefully.
- Use peer feedback as part of your revision.
- Ask questions before deadlines.
- Focus on learning and iteration, not perfection.

📌 **Iteration as the Core Method**

*This section names the course's epistemological commitment: **knowledge is built through iteration.**This is the same claim that underlies Agile, Lean UX, and every continuous improvement framework in the industry.*

'Focus on learning and iteration, not perfection' is not a comfort statement—it is a design philosophy stated in plain language. Students who internalize this are prepared for roles where shipping a good-enough v1 and improving it beats waiting for a perfect v0.

The five-item list is itself a usability decision: it is short enough to remember, specific enough to act on, and organized to build confidence rather than anxiety.

Design Summary

Eight design decisions worth noting in this syllabus:

1	**Writing as interaction design**	Reframes the entire course from production to systems thinking before any assignment is named.
2	**Norman quote as course argument**	24 words that state the semester's central claim: failure to understand users is the real design problem.
3	**Dual-listed UG/grad structure**	Same projects, differentiated depth. Models professional team dynamics where seniority means more conceptual rigor, not different work.
4	**Tool-agnostic philosophy**	Teaches adaptability, not software. Produces practitioners who can evaluate tools, not just operate them.
5	**Peer review as professional practice**	Explicit timing dependency with real consequences. The 'cannot be made up' rule is a career lesson, not a penalty.
6	**Missing component policy with professional parallel**	Fair and instructive simultaneously. Names the workplace consequence so the policy teaches a mental model, not just a rule.
7	**AI policy by authorship, not detection**	Verbal defense as the accountability mechanism. Mirrors portfolio review and interview practice exactly.
8	**Iteration as the course's epistemology**	'Learning through iteration, not perfection' is not comfort; it is the philosophical claim underlying Agile, Lean UX, and every continuous improvement framework.

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